Nonetheless, the redoubtable François Bernier did visit Kashmir, and left a detailed eye-witness account of the province that was used by the Mughal Emperors as a summer retreat.[20] He tells us that there were two wooden bridges over the Jhelum at Srinagar and beautiful gardens along the river banks. Most of the houses were made of wood, although some larger buildings, including the ruins of ancient Hindu temples, were made of stone. He tells us that the rich owned pleasure boats on Dal Lake and that they threw lovely parties in the summer.

Bernier also tells us that the Mughals used their base in Kashmir to extend their influence into Little Tibet (i.e. Ladakh) and, intriguingly, Greater Tibet (i.e. Tibet itself). The cold, bleak but stunningly beautiful landscape does not seem to have impressed a contemporary chronicler who wrote, 'No other useless place can be compared with it.'[21] I could not disagree more. For me, Ladakh is the most spiritual place in the world. To experience it, spend a full-moon night—alone—on one of the lonely mountain passes. It is impossible to describe the way stars look at these altitudes and the way the moonlight reflects on the bare rocky mountainsides. The moon can be so bright that one could almost read a book by it. I have spent nights in the open in the African savannah and have watched the sun rise over the Mayan pyramids of Tikal—but nothing comes close to a full-moon night in Ladakh.

It appears that the Mughals also made some inroads into Tibet itself. The Tibetans promised to pay an annual tribute, allow the building of a mosque in their capital and to issue coins in the name of Aurangzeb. We know that the Ladakhis did allow a mosque to be built in Leh; it can still be visited at the head of the main bazaar (and just below the old palace). However, given the difficult terrain, the Mughals had no way to ensure compliance from Tibet, and Bernier tells us that no one really believed that the Tibetans would honour the promises.

Bernier was very intrigued by the stories he heard about Tibet, including those about the institution of the Dalai Lama. He tried to question Tibetan merchants about their country but received little useful information. As we